

FALCONS AND CARACARAS

Falcons are no longer considered to be closely related to the main order of birds of prey, the Accipitriformes, but instead have their own order, the Falconiformes.

Falcons have a hooked bill, similar to that of the Accipitriformes, but with an added “notch” used to kill prey that is caught and held in the feet. They also have strong feet with sharp, curved claws. Most have long wings and are marvellous

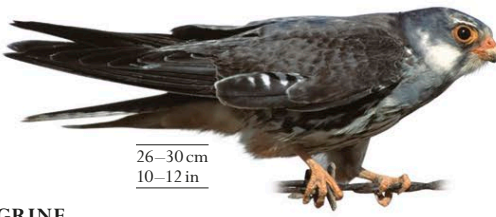
fliers. Some falcons hunt by catching large insects and birds in the air, while others dive onto prey on the ground. Some even take on larger birds in dramatic dives, stooping to strike at speed. Several “hover” at a fixed point above the ground, to search for prey below, often detecting them by the ultraviolet light emitted by their urine. Caracaras also hunt and scavenge on the ground. Unlike most true birds of prey, falcons make no nest but lay eggs on a ledge or in an old nest of some other species.

PHYLUM	CHORDATA
CLASS	AVES
ORDER	FALCONIFORMES
FAMILIES	1
SPECIES	67



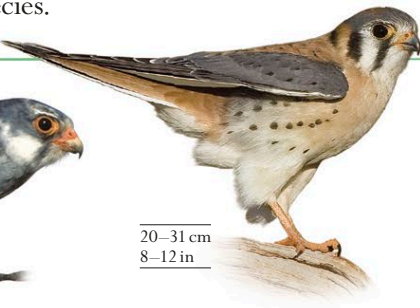
PEREGRINE FALCON
Falco peregrinus
F: Falconidae

As the fastest bird of prey, this falcon dives steeply on prey in mid-air. It is found throughout the world in open country, including tundra and semi-desert.



AMUR FALCON
Falco amurensis
F: Falconidae

Unusually for falcons, this raptor habitually gathers in flocks; it breeds in marshy woodland across Siberia and China and migrates to southern Africa to overwinter.



AMERICAN KESTREL
Falco sparverius
F: Falconidae

Kestrels are small falcons that habitually hover when hunting. This species is distributed throughout the Americas, including the Caribbean islands.



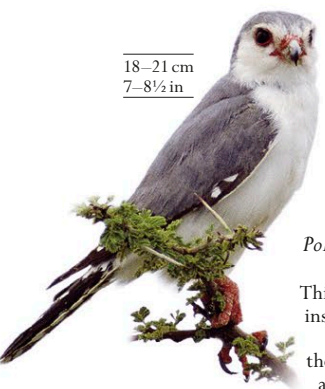
MERLIN
Falco columbarius
F: Falconidae

A nimble predator with a dashing flight, this falcon captures birds in mid-air over hills and moorland across the northern hemisphere.



BAT FALCON
Falco rufigularis
F: Falconidae

This swift-flying American bird hunts birds, bats, and large insects at twilight. It is found from Mexico to Argentina.



AFRICAN PYGMY FALCON
Polihierax semitorquatus
F: Falconidae

This African bird dives for insects and lizards on the ground. It breeds in the nests of weaver birds and may raise a brood co-operatively with others.



CRESTED CARACARA
Caracara cheriway
F: Falconidae

This common species of caracara is found in open country, from the S. USA to northern S. America. It nests in trees or on the ground.



STRIATED CARACARA
Phalcoboenus australis
F: Falconidae

The tendency of this fearless caracara to attack newborn lambs has led to its persecution in its native Falkland Islands.

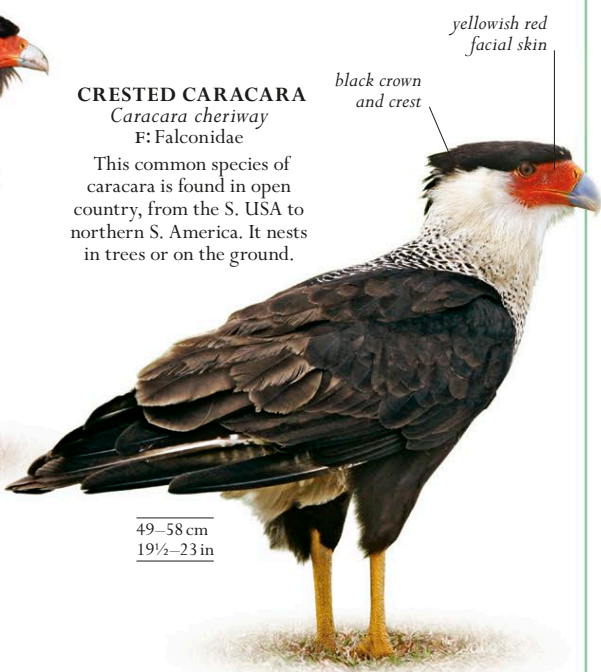
YELLOW-HEADED CARACARA
Milvago chimachima
F: Falconidae

A hawk-like scavenger that also eats oil palm fruit, this bird of southern S. America frequents savanna and forest edges.



MOUNTAIN CARACARA
Phalcoboenus megalopterus
F: Falconidae

Relatives of falcons, caracaras are more sluggish and longer legged. Like other caracaras, this species of the high Andes is a scavenger, but also hunts small animals.



49–58 cm
19½–23 in